the book; but the main work had been done by five academic advisors. These included Mridula Mukherjee, her husband Aditya Mukherjee and her sister Sucheta Mahajan.

Fortunately for these

historians' reputations, this book is not easily available at bookstores.

I was, however, able to obtain a copy from the party's office, and was struck by how slight (in both senses of the word) the volume was. Five historians with PhDs had collectively produced a book that, in size and substance, was substantially inferior to the official history of the Congress published in 1935 by the medical doctor, Pattabhi Sitaramayya.

Still, *Congress and the Making of the Indian Nation* was not written without a motive, or perhaps several. One was to rescue Indira Gandhi, the revered mother-in-law of the Congress president, from the charge of being authoritarian. The excesses of the Emergency of 1975–77 were therefore attributed exclusively to Sanjay Gandhi. A second motive was to cast the current Congress president in the halo of sainthood. Of her decision not to become prime minister in 2004, it was said that 'not since the days of the freedom struggle was such a complete separation of the objective of personal power and the objective of achieving social ideals seen. People looked upon Sonia Gandhi's renunciation of power as reminiscent of the Mahatma.'

For the NMML director to help write the official Congress history was in clear violation of conduct rules, which explicitly prohibit 'any government official from being a member of, or be otherwise associated with, any political party or any organization which takes part in politics; nor shall he [or she] take part in, subscribe in aid of, or assist in any other manner, any political movement or activity.' In the light of what had passed in the past five years, it may not be too cynical to read the NMML

director's participation as a gesture of thanks to her political patrons, as well as a coded application for a further extension.